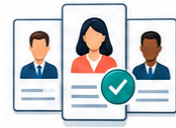


ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Human Resources English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Onboarding and Role Clarity

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

03 Performance Feedback and Documentation

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

04 Employee Relations and Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

06 Policy Communication and Compliance

Clarify missing information before responding.

07 Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

08 Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: job requirement, structured interview, bias, candidate experience.

Model response

Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Translate cultural fit into job-related behavior - Fictional recruiting meeting: a hiring manager asks for good cultural fit, but the role requirements do not specify the relevant behaviors.

2. A software preference mistaken for a requirement - Separate fictional hiring case: a role requires spreadsheet analysis, but a screening draft requires five years with one named spreadsheet product; no product-specific need is established.

3. Clarify a request for executive presence - Separate fictional interview debrief: one interviewer says a candidate lacks executive presence but provides no behavioral example or role-related criterion.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Flexible hours without a defined schedule

A fictional job advertisement says flexible hours, but the hiring manager expects attendance at a fixed weekly meeting. The meeting time and other schedule requirements are unconfirmed. Clarify the actual job requirement before candidates are screened.

Role A: Recruiter: ask what flexibility and required attendance mean for this role.

Role B: Hiring manager: distinguish confirmed expectations from details still needing agreement.

Possible opening: When we say flexible hours, what attendance requirement do candidates actually need to meet?

Success checks

- Clarify the job-related schedule rather than personal circumstances.
- Do not invent the meeting time or availability requirement.
- Agree consistent wording and evidence for candidate discussions.

Add a complication: An interviewer wants to reject applicants based on assumptions about their family responsibilities.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Onboarding and Role Clarity

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A new starter has accounts and equipment but no first-month priorities. Their manager assumes the onboarding checklist covers expectations.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: role clarity, onboarding, manager check-in, success measure.

Model response

Could we agree on three first-month priorities and a check-in date? The checklist covers setup; the new starter also needs to know what successful work looks like.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Accounts ready, first-month priorities missing - Fictional onboarding meeting: a new starter has equipment and accounts but no first-month priorities; the manager assumed the checklist covered expectations.
2. A starter receives competing first-week requests - Separate fictional onboarding case: a new analyst receives a data-cleanup request from the manager and a same-week presentation request from another team; priority is unagreed.

3. A buddy is not the performance decision maker - Separate fictional onboarding exercise: a buddy can explain team routines, but responsibility for setting the starter's objectives remains with the line manager.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Access granted, training owner missing

A fictional new starter can open the case-management system, but no trainer or first supervised task is assigned. The starter is not being assessed yet. Request a bounded training arrangement before treating access as readiness.

Role A: New starter: ask for a trainer, initial task, and check-in arrangement.

Role B: Line manager: accept coordination responsibility and confirm when an arrangement can be proposed.

Possible opening: My access works; could you arrange the initial training and identify who will supervise my first task?

Success checks

- Separate access from demonstrated readiness.
- Request a clear training owner and first-task scope.
- Agree a realistic confirmation point without inventing completed training.

Add a complication: A colleague says account access proves the starter can work independently.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Performance Feedback and Documentation

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

An employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section. The manager wants to discuss the issue without making a judgment about motivation.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: performance gap, documentation, expectation, support plan.

Model response

The last two reports did not include the summary section we agreed on. That made review slower. What would help you include it consistently, and can we check the next report together?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. C - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

05 • Conversations

1. Two reports missing the agreed summary - Fictional feedback conversation: the employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section; the reason is unknown.

2. A handover omits the unresolved question - Separate fictional feedback case: an analyst's two latest handovers omitted the open customer question, requiring the receiving team to ask for it again.

3. Feedback about an interrupted presentation - Separate fictional manager-coaching case: a supervisor interrupted a colleague three times before the colleague finished explaining a staffing concern.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A status label changed without an explanation

A fictional coordinator changed two project statuses from pending to delayed without explaining the reason, causing the receiving team to ask for clarification. The cause of the omission is unknown. Practice behavior-focused feedback and a bounded support step.

Role A: Line manager: describe the two changes and their effect.

Role B: Project coordinator: ask for a clear expectation and agree how to check the next update.

Possible opening: The two status changes had no reason attached, so the receiving team needed a separate clarification.

Success checks

- Use the observed omission and effect.
- Avoid assigning motivation or a character label.
- Agree a specific explanation requirement and follow-up check.

Add a complication: The manager initially calls the coordinator careless rather than describing the missing information.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Employee Relations and Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An employee raises a concern about a colleague. The receiving manager has only one account and is preparing an intake note.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: employee relations, harassment, retaliation, confidentiality.

Model response

I'll record the concern in the employee's own terms and distinguish reported information from established findings. The appropriate process should determine the next steps; we should not prejudge the outcome.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. One employee account is not an investigation finding - Fictional employee-relations intake: a concern about a colleague has been reported, but the manager has only one account and no findings.
2. A changed shift after a complaint needs examination - Separate fictional intake case: an employee reports that their shift changed after they raised a concern; the reason for the change and the decision maker's knowledge

are unknown.

3. A forwarded message without its surrounding exchange - Separate fictional employee-relations case: a manager receives one forwarded workplace message; the surrounding conversation and sender's explanation are unavailable.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A secondhand concern in a team meeting

A fictional manager heard from a colleague that another employee felt excluded from a project meeting. The manager has not spoken with that employee and has no meeting records yet. Practice an intake handoff that identifies the secondhand source.

Role A: Receiving manager: describe what you heard and from whom without inventing the employee's words.

Role B: Employee-relations adviser: ask which facts are direct observations and arrange appropriate follow-up.

Possible opening: This is a secondhand report; I haven't yet heard the employee's own account.

Success checks

- Attribute the report accurately.
- Separate possible exclusion from a finding about intent.
- Agree the appropriate follow-up while respecting information-sharing limits.

Add a complication: A colleague asks you to label the exclusion deliberate before the meeting records are reviewed.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

An employee sees a published pay range and assumes everyone in the role receives the midpoint. The HR team has the relevant compensation policy.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: pay band, job level, equity review, benefits.

Model response

The range describes the span for the role, not a promise of the midpoint. Let's review the applicable policy and the factors the organization uses to explain an individual's position within the range.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. The pay-band midpoint is not everyone's salary - Fictional compensation explanation: a published pay range is available, an employee assumes everyone receives the midpoint, and the HR team has the applicable policy.
2. Base salary and the benefits package are different figures - Separate fictional offer discussion: a candidate asks whether the stated base salary includes the employer's benefits contribution; the offer details have not been

reconciled with the benefits summary.

3. Same job title does not establish the same job level - Separate fictional compensation case: two internal positions share a title, but their job levels and responsibilities have not been compared.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A percentage increase confused with a new band

A fictional compensation notice mentions a proposed salary increase but does not state any change in job level. The employee assumes promotion is confirmed. Discuss the difference while the proposal remains under review.

Role A: People manager: distinguish a salary proposal from a confirmed level change.

Role B: Compensation adviser: identify what the actual notice supports and what needs verification.

Possible opening: The notice proposes a salary change; it does not confirm a promotion or new job level.

Success checks

- Keep salary, job level, and approval status distinct.
- Do not promise either outcome from the proposal alone.
- Agree a document-based clarification through the appropriate review process.

Add a complication: The manager wants to announce a promotion to improve morale before approval.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Policy Communication and Compliance

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved. HR has not yet reviewed the request under the applicable process.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: policy, accommodation, precedent, compliance.

Model response

Could you describe the requested adjustment and the work requirement involved? We'll review it through the appropriate process. I cannot confirm an outcome before that review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. A work-adjustment request is not automatic approval - Fictional HR clarification: a manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved; the applicable process review has not occurred.
2. A policy date and a publication date differ - Separate fictional policy exercise: an internal notice was posted on Monday but says the policy takes effect the following month; a manager assumes it applies immediately.

3. An informal yes with no confirmed authority - Separate fictional HR case: a team lead informally said yes to a schedule request, but their authority and the applicable approval process are unconfirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A policy answer from an unverified handbook version

A fictional manager uses a saved handbook to answer an employee's request, but the current handbook version has not been checked. No approval or rejection has been communicated. Clarify which version applies before responding.

Role A: HR coordinator: request the version reference and applicable-date check.

Role B: Line manager: acknowledge the uncertainty and agree to use the verified policy source.

Possible opening: Before we answer, could we confirm that this saved handbook is the version that applies to the request?

Success checks

- Distinguish familiar wording from an applicable policy.
- Do not invent a legal rule or request outcome.
- Agree the source check and responsible clarification route.

Add a complication: A coworker says the old wording must still apply because it is easier to understand.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Two colleagues disagree about who owns a recurring task. Both say the other failed to help, but the responsibilities were never documented.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: mediation, behavioral example, operating agreement, accountability.

Model response

Let's identify the task, the handoff point, and what each person understood. Then we can agree on responsibilities and a check-in instead of continuing with assumptions about intent.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 · Conversations

1. A recurring task with undocumented ownership - Fictional facilitated meeting about Friday's dashboard: ownership is undocumented, and any earlier verbal agreement is unconfirmed. Analyst Nora receives raw data Thursday at 16:00; coordinator Owen receives returns figures Friday at 10:00. Team manager Priya can assign responsibilities.

2. Who books the meeting and who prepares the agenda? - Separate fictional facilitated meeting: room booking is due Wednesday at noon and the agenda Thursday at 16:00. Room coordinator Eli needs a confirmed headcount; agenda coordinator Sana has topics but lacks presenter confirmations. Project manager Jo can assign responsibilities. Headcount and room availability remain unknown.

3. Two deadlines competing for one employee's time - Separate fictional facilitated discussion: sales needs a customer briefing Friday at noon; operations prefers its internal summary Friday but can accept Monday. Analyst Ren estimates four hours for each and has five working hours available before the customer deadline. Ren also has four working hours available Monday. Department head Mira decides priorities.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A handoff deadline means different things

Two fictional colleagues agree on a Thursday handoff, but one means Thursday morning and the other means end of day. No time was previously agreed. Facilitate a specific future arrangement without blaming either interpretation as a broken promise.

Role A: HR mediator: summarize the ambiguity and invite both scheduling needs.

Role B: Team manager: clarify decision authority and agree a precise future handoff arrangement with the participants.

Possible opening: Thursday was agreed, but a time was not, so let's clarify the next handoff rather than assume a broken agreement.

Success checks

- Separate an ambiguous agreement from proven misconduct.
- Hear the relevant timing needs before assigning a deadline.
- Confirm an owner, specific timing, and an escalation route for future difficulty.

Add a complication: One colleague asks you to record that the other deliberately missed the deadline.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A restructuring message uses the phrase "small changes" even though some positions may be affected. The final details are not yet confirmed.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: restructuring, position elimination, severance, talking points.

Model response

The wording may understate the possible impact. Let's say clearly what is confirmed, what remains undecided, and where employees can ask questions, using the approved communication process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 · Conversations

1. Small changes understates possible position impacts - Fictional restructuring-message review: a draft says small changes although some positions may be affected; final details remain unconfirmed.
2. Correcting a promise that no roles would change - Separate fictional restructuring case: a manager said no roles would change, but the approved planning status is that role impacts remain under review.

3. A planning chart mistaken for a final structure - Separate fictional employee conversation: team coordinator Alex saw an organization chart without a draft label. HR program manager Sam is correcting that communication. The chart is a planning draft; final restructuring decisions, individual impacts, and any severance arrangements are unconfirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A consultation described as an announcement

A fictional calendar invitation labels an upcoming restructuring consultation a final announcement. The meeting is intended to gather input, and no final position decisions exist. Practice a correction that makes the meeting's purpose clear.

Role A: People communications lead: acknowledge the misleading invitation and explain the consultation purpose.

Role B: Department manager: ask how to answer questions without promising a particular outcome.

Possible opening: The invitation called this a final announcement, but the meeting is a consultation to gather input.

Success checks

- Correct the invitation's decision-status implication.
- Distinguish an opportunity for input from a guaranteed outcome.
- Agree reviewed talking points and the appropriate route for unresolved questions.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to say consultation guarantees that nothing will change.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Human Resources English

Professional audience: HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Original fictional case: A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: job requirement: A capability, qualification, or responsibility needed for a role. / structured interview: An interview using planned job-related questions and consistent evaluation criteria. / bias: A systematic tendency that can distort judgment, measurement, selection, or results. / candidate experience: An applicant's experience of an organization's hiring process.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Human Resources English

Professional audience: HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Original fictional case: A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level